

# The purpose of grammar

THE STRUCTURE OF A LANGUAGE IS KNOWN AS ITS GRAMMAR.

Words are the building blocks of language. Grammar is a set of rules that determines how these building blocks can be put together in different combinations to create well-formed phrases, clauses, and sentences, which enable and enrich conversation.

The **first** published **book** about English **grammar**, *Pamphlet for Grammar*, was written by **William Bullokar** in 1586.

## Evolving languages

All languages change over time. As a language evolves, its grammar adapts to incorporate new words and ways of organizing them. Different languages have different sets of

rules, so sentences are formed in different ways, even if they mean the same thing. Thus, it's often difficult to translate sentences exactly from another language into English.

### ▷ English word order

This is a grammatically correct sentence in English. The verb *read* follows the subject, *I*, and the adjective *good* follows the linking verb *was*.

**I read my sister's book,  
which was good.**



### ▷ Old English word order

This sentence has been translated into Old English, and then translated directly back into modern English. The first part of the sentence still makes grammatical sense in modern English, but in the second part of the sentence, the verb is now at the end.

**I read the book of my  
sister, which good was.**



### ▷ German word order

This sentence has been translated into German, and then translated directly back into English. The word order is the same as that of the Old English sentence, because Old English is a Germanic language.

**I read the book of my  
sister, which good was.**



## Learning grammar

When a child learns a language, he or she absorbs information about how that language is structured. This knowledge is refined as the child learns to read and write. Although much of this learning is subconscious, some grammatical rules simply have to be learned.

I'm coming with  
you, aren't I?

Wrong! What you meant to  
say was, "I'm coming with  
you, am I not?"

